

Selecting the Package

Selecting accounting software is indeed a tough job. With so many new features being added in every upgraded version, it tends to be a bit confusing to figure out which accounting software would be the most appropriate for you.

A home user should generally be looking for taxation, banking capabilities, etc, whereas a small-time businessman should be looking not only for these features, but also for product costing, inventory control, MIS, etc.

So you should understand your current requirements and identify your future

needs, because it's not just about the money you spend to buy these packages. There is an enormous amount of work that goes into entering the data, which is worth more than the cost of the software. If something goes wrong with the data, or the year-end reports don't get done the way they're supposed to be, the situation at work could become really messy.

Here are some of the things to keep in mind before buying accounting software: The install size should not be too large or heavy on the system.

■ There should be adequate help and doc-

umentation, so novice users don't feel lost.

■ The interface should be simple and configurable. Also make sure that it is a single entry package—no double entry should be required to update reports.

■ Check for tiny but important details such as whether document numbering and date range are set up automatically or manually, whether there is support for an accounting period of more than a year, and whether you can back up not just on floppies but on other available media too.

■ The package should have housekeeping and maintenance features.

looking through the list of tasks in the index.

DOS-based ACE has hardly any documentation on the software itself. However, a pretty detailed manual is included with it. The manual starts off by giving some tips to prevent you from getting into trouble. The installation procedure is also explained well.

Easy Computing's help comes in the form of a small manual, which explains the lengthy procedure of copying all the files and starting installation. The quality of the manual isn't too impressive—there's not even a clear index that you can refer to.

FACT's manual comes in the form of a Word document. There is a really well-designed index, but an HTML or PDF format document with links would have been a better option for browsing through the help document.

Wings2000 Pro's manual is probably the biggest amongst all the accounting packages. It has been created for all three versions of Wings—Wings2000 Plus,

Wings2000 Pro and Wings2000 Net. Arthalekha, on the other hand, has a bare minimum of help provided, which is in the form of the Windows help format. Not much accounting terminology is explained; the emphasis is on shortcut keys.

Simply Accounting has a very nice on-screen help file that is well categorised. It also explains a lot of accountancy jargon. Compared to the other packages, it comes out tops with its comprehensive documentation and easy-to-use help.

Ease of use

Even after spending a lot of money on an accounting package, if you're uncomfortable using it, then it might end up lying on your computer without you ever doing any quality work on it. Hence the software needs to be user-friendly and have an inviting look and feel.

Most of the products have the standard international drop-down menu style that makes it convenient for first-time users, barring Tally and Simply Accounting, which have their own style of menus. By and large, the design and layout were also clear and easy to understand.

Simply Accounting is really a software for beginners. The software comes with a huge

archive of templates for allowing users to get their work done by simply answering a set of questions. It stands apart with its Web-like feel and distinctive look.

On the other end of the spectrum are Tally, FACT and Wings2000 Pro, with advanced features and also a complex interface that a new user would definitely find difficult.

Account 21 has followed the generic menu appearance. The sub-menus have colourful icons

depicting each entry type. This can be a little confusing initially, but once you get used to it, you should have no problems.

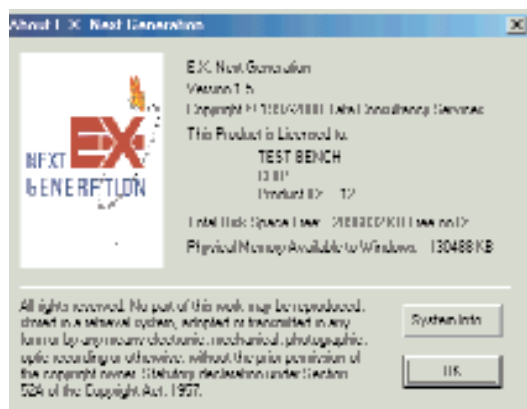
The DOS-based packages are straightforward and uncomplicated.

Other accounting software, such as Arthalekha and Wings 2000 Pro, provide multilingual support. Arthalekha even starts up with a Hindi interface and shows up your preferred language once you change the settings.

We also checked out whether it was easy to enter data into the program or whether it was a complicated procedure wherein one had to switch through numerous windows.

Simply Accounting leads here as well. With a neat interface and design, it saves you a lot of time and energy.

The data entry screen in Simply Accounting is also very well designed and there is even the option of customising its appearance by choosing from among the five skins available.



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